



lead though. It was something few could claim against Lasha.

The gold was no longer a certainty. To be sure, one would think Lasha would pull ahead in the clean and jerk but then one couldn't be so sure. It was a three-way fight for gold between Lasha, Lalayan and Minasyan.

Once the lesser placings were done in the clean and jerk section – where weightlifters could pull the bar up to their chest before pushing it over the head, Minasyan was the first to come out. He put 245kg on the bar and lifted it. Lasha had to go bigger. He posted 247 kg – the most he's started a clean-and-jerk competition at the Olympics with. Although he made it, it was clearly a lot more of a struggle than in previous years. But Lalayan, the 25-year-old Armenian, did it too.

He had been matching Lasha lift for lift but now Lalayan began to reach his limit too. He loaded 252 kilos on the bar – and made the lift. He had made a new personal best.

It was time for Lasha to step up. He loaded 255 kilos on the bar.

Lasha usually crossed himself in orthodox fashion when he stepped up onto the weightlifting platform, but this time he made the religious gesture multiple times.

When he began the lift, you could see just why he needed all the divine intervention he could get. This was the hardest anyone had seen Lasha work under the bar. It moved almost in slow motion to his chest. When he threw the bar overhead, it was clear he could barely control it. The momentum of the weight dragged the 171-kilo man with it. By the time he could bring a stop to its movement, he was almost standing perpendicular to the judges out in front of the platform. It was sheer heart and brute strength that allowed him to lock his arms out with weight overhead. His body shook uncontrollably. One of the judges ruled it a foul but the other two let it stand.

Lasha barely could. The effort had taken almost everything from him. His coaches, including former Olympic champion Giorgi Asanidze, had to physically hold him up as he

went backstage. It was the most anyone had seen Lasha struggle on the international stage in a decade but it was enough. Minasyan twice failed a lift at 255 kilos which would have given him the lead. Lalayan attempted but failed a lift at 256kg.

Though it meant Lasha had won, he still had a lift left in the bank. This is normally when lifters make a 'glory lift' and attempt a near-impossible weight with nothing to lose. Lasha though was spent. He sat on his seat backstage and didn't make an attempt – once again for the first time in a decade. His winning total was 470kg – just three kilos more than Lalayan. It was the narrowest of his career.

Lasha would later go on to say this was the most valuable medal of his sports career. He says he would go for a fourth. It is uncertain if that will be the case.

His performance at the Paris Olympics reminds one of the old saying: "Father Time is undefeated." But for at least one last Olympics, Lasha has managed to prove he's still stronger than him.